TEACHER GUIDE | LESSON 15

Romans Part 1

God Justifies the Ungodly

BIG IDEA All people stand guilty under sin, but God reveals his righteousness by justifying sinners through faith in Jesus Christ, leaving no room for boasting.

Purpose and outcome

By the end of the lesson, the class should be able to:

- trace Paul's argument from universal guilt to God's saving action in Christ;
- explain justification as God's gracious verdict received by faith rather than earned by law-keeping;
- show why Abraham leaves both Jews and Gentiles without grounds for boasting; and
- state how the gospel displays both God's justice and his mercy.

Lesson at a glance

TIME	MOVEMENT
0:00-5:00	Opening question and prayer
5:00-10:00	Romans in one paragraph and the gospel thesis - 1:16-17
10:00-20:00	Every mouth silenced - 1:18-3:20
20:00-35:00	God's righteousness revealed in Christ - 3:21-31
35:00-43:00	Abraham believed the promise - 4:1-25
43:00-48:00	Choose two discussion questions
48:00-50:00	Synthesis, homework, and prayer

Before class

Write on the board: If God judges fairly, how can guilty people ever be right with him?

Controlling question: How can God be righteous and justify the guilty?

Mark Romans 1:16-17; 3:9-26; and 4:1-5, 16-25. Read only these selections aloud. Summarize the rest of chapters 1-4.

PROTECT THE SPINE Required: every person is accountable to God; God justifies by grace through faith because of Christ; Abraham shows that the promise is for all who believe. Summarize: Paul's travel plans, the detailed indictments in chapters 1-2, and David in 4:6-8. If time: the meaning of righteousness, redemption, and sacrifice of atonement. Safely omit: the faith or faithfulness translation debate, a full New Perspective discussion, and every theory of atonement.

The whole lesson in one claim

Romans 1-4 removes every human claim to moral superiority. Gentile, moral critic, and Torah-possessing Jew all stand accountable before God. The gospel does not offer a better ladder. It announces what God has done in Jesus Christ and gives the same gracious verdict to everyone who believes.

CENTRAL LINE No one has a case to present before God, but everyone may receive the gift God provides in Christ.

Setting Why Paul wrote to Rome

Paul had not founded the churches in Rome. He wrote to introduce his gospel, strengthen unity among Jewish and Gentile believers, and seek support for a mission toward Spain (1:8-15; 15:22-33). Romans is a carefully argued missionary letter to real congregations, not a detached theology textbook. The Jew-Gentile question runs through the argument even when Paul addresses the guilt of every person. (BibleProject, Guide to Romans; Mathis, TGC Bible Commentary, Romans 1:1-17.)

1. CORE The gospel reveals God's righteousness

Romans 1:16-17 states the letter's thesis. The gospel is God's power for salvation to everyone who believes, first to the Jew and then to the Gentile. In it God's righteousness is revealed. The phrase includes God's righteous character and his faithful saving action. In the gospel, the righteous God acts to put sinners in the right through faith.

TERM	WORKING DEFINITION FOR CLASS
Gospel	The announcement that Jesus the Messiah died, rose, reigns, and saves all who believe.
God's righteousness	God's righteous character expressed in faithful judgment and saving action.
Faith	Trusting God's promise fulfilled in Jesus, not performing a work that earns a verdict.

Do not spend the lesson solving 'from faith to faith.' The NIV's 'by faith from first to last' captures Paul's emphasis: salvation begins and continues by trusting God's promise, not by establishing a personal record of merit.

2. CORE Every mouth is silenced

Romans 1:18-3:20 works like a courtroom argument. Paul begins with humanity's exchange of God's glory for idols, then turns toward the person who judges others, and finally addresses the person who possesses the law. Each new listener may agree with the previous indictment until Paul closes every escape route.

PASSAGE	PAUL'S STEP
1:18-32	Humanity suppresses truth, exchanges worship, and is handed over to the disorder it chooses.
2:1-29	The moral and religious judge cannot claim exemption; possessing the law is not the same as obeying it.
3:1-8	Jewish privilege is real, but human unfaithfulness does not cancel God's faithfulness or remove accountability.
3:9-20	Jew and Gentile alike are under sin. The law exposes guilt; it does not provide a successful defense.

Read 3:9-20 and emphasize Paul's destination: every mouth is silenced and the whole world is accountable to God. Romans 1 is not ammunition for one group to condemn another. Romans 2 turns the accusation toward the accuser, and Romans 3 places everyone together under sin.

What Paul means by works of the law

In 3:20 and 3:28, works of the law are deeds performed in obedience to the Mosaic law as a basis for God's favorable verdict. Circumcision and other Jewish identity markers matter to the Jew-Gentile argument, but Paul does not restrict the phrase to those markers. His larger point is that no one establishes righteousness before God by law-keeping. The law gives knowledge of sin.

3. CORE God justifies through Christ

The words 'But now' in 3:21 announce the turn. God has acted apart from law-keeping, although the Law and the Prophets witness to what he has done. The same righteousness is available to all who believe because there is no difference in either the problem or the remedy.

WORD IN 3:21-26	WHAT IT CONTRIBUTES
Justified	God's courtroom verdict that the guilty believer is in the right before him. It is a gift, not a wage.
Grace	God acts freely for people who cannot establish a claim upon him.
Redemption	Christ liberates sinners at the cost of his own life.
Sacrifice of atonement	Christ's death deals with sin and demonstrates that God does not ignore evil when he forgives.

The controlling question receives its answer in 3:26: God is just and the one who justifies those who have faith in Jesus. Forgiveness is not God pretending sin does not matter. At the cross, God deals with sin and gives the verdict Christ's people could never earn. Boasting is excluded because the verdict is received by faith. (Mathis, TGC Bible Commentary, Romans 3:21-31.)

Abraham proves that the promise comes by faith

Romans 4 is not an appendix. Paul appeals to Abraham because both Jewish and Gentile believers need a shared father. Genesis 15:6 says Abraham believed God and it was credited to him as righteousness. He received the verdict before circumcision and centuries before the Mosaic law. Therefore he cannot be used as evidence that ethnic status or law-keeping earns God's promise.

ABRAHAM'S STORY	PAUL'S CONCLUSION
Faith was credited, not paid as a wage	Justification is a gift to the ungodly, so boasting is impossible.
Declared righteous before circumcision	Abraham is father of uncircumcised believers as well as circumcised believers.
Trusted God's promise despite his deadened body	Faith rests on the God who gives life to the dead and keeps his word.
The words were written also for us	God credits righteousness to those who trust the God who raised Jesus from the dead.

Discussion choose two

1. Why does Paul take so much time to show that every group is under sin?
2. How can God forgive guilty people without becoming unjust?
3. How does Abraham's story challenge both religious pride and hopelessness?

Likely rabbit trails

A complete debate over Romans 1 and sexual ethics; the New Perspective on Paul; every meaning of God's righteousness; propitiation versus expiation; faith in Christ versus Christ's faithfulness; and harmonizing Paul and James. Give a short answer if needed, then return to Paul's argument: all are guilty, God has acted in Christ, and the promise is received by faith.

Leader preparation

Sources used: Donny Ray Mathis, 'Romans,' The Gospel Coalition Bible Commentary, sections on 1:16-17, 3:9-4:25; BibleProject, Guide to Romans and Romans 1-4 overview; The Gospel Coalition, Introduction to Romans. ECO connection: Essential Tenet III.A, God's grace in Christ. Official text: eco-pres.org/constitution/. Before Lesson 16: Read Romans 5-8. Mark every reference to Adam, Christ, sin, death, life, the Spirit, suffering, and hope.